SEEDLINGS · WEEK 01

Fearfully and Wonderfully Made

Unit 1 · Pillar 1: Design · Immune



Know that the Lord Himself is God; it is He who has made us, and not we ourselves; we are His people and the sheep of His pasture.

Psalm 100:3

WEEK AT A GLANCE

MONDAY *Read the Word and meet elderberry, God's design for a strong immune system.*

TUESDAY *Explore elderberry with the senses and name its gift, the immunomodulator.*

WEDNESDAY *Make elderberry syrup in the Kitchen Lab, opening Week 2.*

THURSDAY *Elderberry's story: a 1600s doctor's whole book on the elder, plus a clay relief.*

FRIDAY *Garden lesson: the living soil food web; then review the week.*

Subjects woven this week: Bible · Character · Language Arts · History · Geography · Latin · Science · Math · Health · Art

AROUND THE TABLE

Elderberry only cheers on the defenders God built inside you. What is one amazing thing your body does to keep itself well?

KITCHEN LAB - SUPPLIES NEEDED

- 1 cup dried elderberries
- 4 cups water
- 1 cup honey
- Pot, strainer, and clean jar
- Tape and a sharpie



Elderberry

Sambucus nigra

Read-Aloud & Discussion

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HERB

Elderberry

Immune

STORY ORIENTATION

Turn to Psalm 100 and read all five verses aloud together. It is a psalm that cannot sit still: it calls the whole earth to shout, to sing, to come through God's gates with thanksgiving. And in the middle of all that noise sits the quiet fact everything this year will stand on: 'It is He who has made us, and not we ourselves; we are His people and the sheep of His pasture' (Psalm 100:3). You did not make yourself. God did, on purpose, down to the last hidden cell. Hold that, because it opens a question worth chasing all year: if the God who so carefully built our bodies also planted the gardens, might He have tucked real help for those bodies inside the plants? This week's herb, the dark elderberry, is the first of thirty-six clues. For centuries families simmered its dark berries into a winter syrup, sensing that God had tucked something good inside. As you close the psalm, thank Him you are not an accident but His handiwork, and when your body fails you, be still and trust the One who made it.

KEY CONCEPT

God designed elderberry's dark purple berries with compounds that help the body's own immune system fight off sickness.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why did families long ago cook elderberries into syrup every fall, and what were they getting ready for?
2. Elderberry doesn't fight the sickness itself; it wakes up your body's own defenders. Why might God have built your body to fight for you?
3. If God designed your body on purpose, and not by accident, what is one worry you could hand back to Him and rest in this week?

MEMORY VERSE

Know that the Lord Himself is God; it is He who has made us, and not we ourselves; we are His people and the sheep of His pasture.

ELDERBERRY CHANT

Elderberry, dark and blue,
simmered slow to syrup sweet,
wakes the guards inside of you
when the winter colds you meet.

Today's threads: Bible · Language Arts · Science

TEACHER NOTES

LITTLE SEEDLINGS

Read just the opening aloud, then have them paint the elderberry's deep purple and call it a 'medicine color.'

OLDER SEEDLINGS

Have them explain in their own words how the purple anthocyanins help the immune system fight a cold.

TODAY'S WORD: IMMUNE SYSTEM. The body's built-in defense team that fights off germs.
How woven
Bible: Psalm 100:3 and how God made us on purpose
Language Arts: reading the passage and retelling the elder's winter-medicine story
Science: the dark anthocyanins that help the immune system fight viruses

LEARNING BENCHMARKS

ELA (Reading)·R2 – read and discuss Psalm 100
ELA (Speaking)·R3 – answer the week's higher-order discussion questions

Discovery

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DISCOVERY LESSON

Hold a sprig of elder and look closely: hundreds of tiny cream flowers, each with five petals, spread into a flat, lacy circle like a doily. Lean in and you catch a soft, honey-musky smell. By late summer those flowers become heavy, drooping clusters of berries so dark they look black, and if you press one it stains your fingers deep purple. That color is a clue to the medicine inside: the purple pigments, called anthocyanins, are the part that helps our immune system fight back. We never taste the raw berries, though; they must be cooked into a tart-sweet syrup. God tucked a hidden helper inside one small berry.

CORE QUESTION:

Elderberry's deep purple is a clue to the good inside. What other bright-colored fruits or veggies do you think are good for you?

TEACHING PROGRESSION

1. Why do you think elderberry hides its medicine inside its color and keeps it locked away until the berries are cooked?
2. An immunomodulator is a plant that helps the body's own defenses work better. What did you notice about elderberry that shows it helps the body fight back?

Little Seedlings: Let them answer aloud and draw their idea; offer the starter "The color helps because..."

Older Seedlings: Have them name one other immunomodulator food and explain how its color or nutrients help.

NATURE NOTEBOOK

Draw an elderberry's flat, lacy flower cluster and, beside it, the drooping bunch of berries. Color the berries deep purple and label both.

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Today's threads: Bible · Science · Art · Math

TEACHER NOTES

TODAY'S WORD: IMMUNOMODULATOR. A plant that helps steady and strengthen the body's defenses.

How woven

Bible: God tucked a hidden helper of health inside one small, dark berry.

Science: the purple anthocyanins are the pigment that also helps the immune system respond.

Art: sketching the lacy flower cluster and the deep-purple berries, both labeled.

LEARNING BENCHMARKS

Science·R2 – observe elderberry's lacy flowers and dark, staining berries

Science·R3 – identify its purple pigment (anthocyanins) and how it wakes up the body's defenses

Art·R3 – sketch and label an elderberry flower cluster and its berries

Latin·R2 – learn the Latin name, Sambucus nigra

Math·R3 – in the Student Notebook, Little Seedlings: meaning of multiplication; Older Seedl and subtract big numbers

Kitchen Lab

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KITCHEN LAB

Today we start a batch of elderberry syrup: dark berries simmered down and sweetened with honey, sealed now and opened in Week 2.
A syrup is one of the oldest ways to turn strong medicine into something sweet and gentle, perfect for soothing coughs and sore throats.
To use: children 1 teaspoon, adults 1 tablespoon, up to 3 times a day; more than that loosens the bowels.
Shelf life: about 2 weeks from the day you make it, in the fridge.

TEACHING NOTE

Why a syrup? Elderberry's medicine, its purple anthocyanins, dissolves well in hot water. Simmering draws it out and honey sweetens it, while gentle cooking breaks down the raw berry's harmful parts.

STEP-BY-STEP

Elderberry Syrup

1. Put 1 cup dried elderberries and 4 cups water in a pot.
2. With a grown-up, boil, then simmer until the liquid cooks down by half (about 45 minutes).
3. Cool a little, then strain out the berries, pressing to squeeze out every drop.
4. When the liquid is warm, not hot, stir in 1 cup honey.
5. Pour into a clean jar; label it with tape and a sharpie: today's date and the open date.
6. Store in the fridge; open in Week 2.

Open on Week 2.

BEAR MOMENT

Never eat raw or unripe elderberries, and never the leaves, stems or bark. Cook first. No honey syrup for a baby under one year.

ELDERBERRY CHANT

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Today's threads: Science · Math

TEACHER NOTES

TODAY'S WORD: MENSTRUUM. The liquid, like water, alcohol, or honey, that pulls a plant's medicine out.
How woven
Science: water dissolves elderberry's purple anthocyanins, while gentle cooking breaks down the raw berry's harmful parts.
Math: simmer the berry liquid down by half, then stir in 1 cup of honey, half as much as the liquid left.
Safety: no honey for a baby under one year, and check with a provider before using elderberry with any medicine.

LEARNING BENCHMARKS

Science·R3 – explain why cooking pulls elderberry's water-soluble anthocyanins into syrup
Math·R3 – measure the berries and honey and simmer the syrup to reduce by half
Health·R2 – always cook elderberries; never eat them raw
ELA (Vocabulary)·R2 – learn the term "menstruum"

History & Art

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HISTORY LESSON

Almost four hundred years ago, a doctor named Martin Blochwich wrote a book, in Latin, all about one shrub, the elder. In English it was called Anatomia Sambuci, or The Anatomy of the Elder. A man who signed himself C. de Iryngio turned it into English, and he dated his note 'At the Camp in Athol, June 30. 1651.' The book tells how to make a 'Rob.' Press the juice from ripe berries, strain it, and thicken it 'on a soft and clear fire.' Some people added 'a little sugar.' It says women gave it to their 'coughing unquiet children.' Later, the writer John Evelyn said that if the elder's uses were well known, a countryman could 'fetch a remedy from every hedge.' The God who planted the hedges tucked help inside them too.

CLIMATE & GROWING ZONE

In the wild, elder grows along the damp edges of European woodlands and hedgerows, where the soil stays cool and moist. That cool, wet home is part of why its berry is cooling and drying for the body. A hardy shrub, elder grows outdoors in Zones 5 to 8, returning each spring. Find your zone and see if an elder could grow where you live.

ART ACTIVITY

In your notebook's art box, draw a large, fancy capital E the way old books decorated the first letter of a page. Fill its edges with elder leaves, lacy white flowers, and clusters of blue-black berries, and add gold or bright color. Letter beneath it: 'A remedy from every hedge.'

Go further (grown-ups): sculpt the letter as a relief tile in air-dry clay, press real elder leaves into the wet clay for texture, and brush it gold once it dries.

ON THE MAP

Elder grows across Europe and the British Isles, in lands like England, France, and Germany. Find Europe on a globe, then look for the British Isles just off its northwest coast.

ELDERBERRY CHANT

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Today's threads: History · Art · Bible

TEACHER NOTES

TODAY'S WORD: ROB. An old name for fruit juice cooked down until it is thick.

How woven

History: Martin Blochwich's book on the elder gave a recipe for elderberry rob.

Art: a decorated capital E, like the fancy first letters in old books.

Bible: God tucked help inside the plants growing in every hedge.

LEARNING BENCHMARKS

History·R2 – retell what Martin Blochwich's book said about elderberry rob

Geography·R2 – locate Europe and the British Isles on a globe

Art·R3 – letter a decorated capital the way old books began a page

ELA (Vocabulary)·R2 – learn the term "rob"

Garden & Review

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GARDEN ACTIVITY

LIVING SOIL. Scoop up a handful of garden soil and look close: it is not dirt, it is alive. One handful holds more tiny creatures than there are people on earth, all quietly working for free. God designed the soil to feed your plants, so a wise gardener feeds the soil and lets it do the work; we do not build fertility in a factory, we protect the life already there.
DO: Spread a scoop on white paper and count the living things, tiny roots, bugs, threads, and crumbs. Water a bare patch and a mulched patch and see which stays soft and dark.
Little Seedlings: find one living thing in the soil and name it.
Older Seedlings: explain why feeding the soil beats feeding the plant.

IN YOUR GARDEN:
Find your USDA hardiness zone (or your country's equivalent). Research 3 herbs that grow well in YOUR climate and this season; list each with its zone range.

NEXT WEEK

Next week we meet tulsi, called the queen of herbs and planted by the front door in India. Its leaves carry a calming, steadying gift for worried, restless days.

WEEK REVIEW

1. What is elderberry's gift to the body, and how does its deep purple color hint at the medicine hidden inside?
2. We cooked the berries into syrup instead of eating them raw. Why does elderberry need to be cooked before we use it?
3. John Evelyn wrote that a countryman could 'fetch a remedy from every hedge.' Why do you think one little shrub earned such big praise?
4. Elderberry doesn't fight sickness for you; it wakes up the defenders God already built into your body. How does that show you were fearfully and wonderfully made?

MEMORY VERSE RECAP

Recite Psalm 100:3.

ELDERBERRY CHANT

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"This week we made our medicine now to open next week. The best things ask for trust and time, and God is faithful with both." – Vovó

Today's threads: Science · Bible · Character

TEACHER NOTES

TODAY'S WORD: SOIL FOOD WEB. The huge web of tiny living things in healthy soil that feed the plants. How woven
Science: one handful of living soil holds more creatures than there are people on earth, all cycling nutrients.
Bible: God designed the soil to do the work; we protect the life He placed there rather than making it ourselves.
Character: humility, letting God's design work instead of forcing it.

WORKS CITED

NASB 1995, Ps 100:3; Kew POWO; USDA PLANTS; NIH NCCIH (2024); CDC (2026); King's Dispensatory (1898); U.S. Dispensatory (1918); Grieve (1931); Blochwich, Anatomia Sambuci (1677); Evelyn, Sylva (1664); UMaine Ext. (2025); Illinois Ext.

FURTHER READING

Hildegard of Bingen: Scientist, Composer, Healer, and Saint – Demi (family read)

LEARNING BENCHMARKS

Science·R2 – explain how the living soil food web feeds the garden
Math·R3 – count the living things in one scoop of soil
ELA·R3 – answer the week's four higher-order review questions